department of defense, and the state department, considered Pakistan as the linchpin for any strategy to fight against Al Qaeda and the Taliban.[3] NATO and the US needed Islamabad's support to enter Afghanistan, to halt the Taliban insurgency (that was covertly being supported by Pakistan), and to talk to the Taliban to ensure a honourable exit.[4] Pakistan received nearly US$ 19 billion since 2002 as economic and military assistance and an additional US$13 billion as reimbursements from the Coalition Support Fund in order to allow transit to Afghanistan and the use of Pakistan's naval and airport facilities for coalition troops and equipment transfers.[5] India on the other hand, despite having positively overhauled its relationship with the US during the Bush presidency, figured marginally in Washington's 'Af-Pak' canvass.

Despite regular consultations, neither New Delhi nor Washington knew how to work together in Afghanistan.[6] When India had expressed interest in training the Afghan National Army in 2001–02, Washington balked in order to secure Pakistan's support. By the time the US realised that Pakistan was an unreliable ally in Afghanistan, India had lost interest to step in militarily given its ongoing peace talks with Islamabad. Though the two countries tried hard to find common ground for promoting democracy in Afghanistan and helping in the reconstruction of the war-torn country, this trend of political bad timing continued throughout the war.[7] The political mismatch between New Delhi and Washington would have been highly comic had Afghanistan's situation not been as scary and tragic as it was. But more than the initial US-Pakistan alliance, it was the US withdrawal that worried India. Just like the Soviet case, premature drawdown of the coalition forces from Afghanistan had the potential to put Pakistan in the driving seat in Kabul. India was worried that the tragedy of 1992 might repeat itself as a farce in 2014, and Karzai (and later Ghani) might meet with Najibullah's fate.

Similar to its 1987 request to Moscow, New Delhi asked Washington to go slow with the withdrawal. But much like the 1980s, when Pakistan mattered more to the Soviet Union despite India being the bigger South Asian partner, the same was the case with the US. India was important, but not critical. This chapter highlights how, given its limited strategic importance in Afghanistan, India managed the early phases of the war, its slow-motion unraveling, and subsequent